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The Ha Giang loop: a four-day road trip

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* # The Ha Giang loop: a four-day road trip

The Ha Giang Loop, an adventurer's paradise. All photos by Jason Zullo

High in the north of Vietnam is a place where the road winds through jaw-dropping canyons and breathtaking mountain passes. The [Ha Giang loop](https://motogo.tours/ha-giang-motorbike-tours) is a dream come true for adventures travellers craving the open road. Pack your gear, charge your batteries, and prepare for an adventure.

This four-day route follows the QL4C northeast from Hà Giang to B?o Lâm, and the QL34 southwest from B?o Lâm back to Hà Giang.

Day 1: Ha Giang City to Yen Minh

Morning

Get an early breakfast in Hà Giang city before hitting the road. As you head north on the QL4C, the landscape quickly transforms into a limestone mountain range, covered with lush jungle. Soon you'll reach the Dong Van Karst Plateau, a UNESCO Global Geopark. The highlight of this section of the trip is Heaven's Gate Pass, where you'll get your first taste of exhilarating views along with challenging, tight curves.

Cruising down from Heaven's Gate Pass, you'll arrive in Tam S?n -- a town surrounded by jutting, forested hills -- just in time for lunch. Here the restaurants and road stalls serve classic Northern Vietnamese fare. And like anywhere else in the country, a great Vietnamese coffee is not hard to find.

Afternoon

Once you're refuelled, continue on the QL4C towards Yên Minh. The road follows the beautiful Mien River before climbing through a tall canyon. Cruise through karst plateaus and mountain passes before arriving at Yên Minh, where you can settle in at a local hotel for the evening.

> **TIP:******It is best to contact [a local travel company](https://infinityhagiangloop.com/ha-giang-loop-tours/) for advice on unique itineraries or cozy homestays in small, peaceful areas rich in local character. The most beautiful and popular accommodations tend to sell out quickly, especially during peak season.**

Day 2: The Vietnamese Border

Morning

Enjoy a steaming bowl of pho for breakfast before you set off for Dong Van, taking the QL4C northeast. The steep road quickly rises above the tree line, revealing an otherworldly landscape of eroded limestone karsts with incredible views at every turn. Đèo Chín Khoanh (Nine Turn Pass), is a great place to stop and admire the sets of curved roads descending into the valley below. Stop in the Sà Phìn area for food and fuel.

Afternoon

A three-hour detour takes you to the Lũng Cú Flag Tower. The 360-degree views over the border into China are worth the effort. Back on the QL4C, you'll have no shortage of stunning views on the way to Lăng Vn, where you'll stay. Set aside time to visit a local market, either at night or in the early morning, and see the colourful ethnic minorities going about their business.

> **TIP:** Be sure to check with your host in Dong Van about dates and times for the local markets. It's a cultural experience you won't want to miss.

Day 3: Lăng Vn and Mã Pí Lèng Passes

Morning

Today you'll encounter what is arguably the most mind-blowing stretch of road in all of Vietnam. From Lăng Vn all the way to Mã Pí Lèng Pass, the valley floor drops far below as you wind your way through massive peaks and canyons. The only problem may be the number of stops you feel compelled to make, as every turn is full of picture-perfect views.

Mèo Vc is only 24 kilometres from Lăng Vn, but it will take most of your morning to reach it, if you stop to appreciate the panoramic views along the way. Once there, enjoy this quaint town, which has colourful character and more than a few options for lunch.

Afternoon

For a quick detour, take a left off of QL4C at the bottom of Mã Pí Lèng Pass onto side road 193A. It's a short but fun ride offering a closer look at the winding Nho Qu? River below.

You'll finish the day in B?o Lâm, a small hamlet with wonderfully warm locals. Spend a few hours relaxing in this remote setting, readying yourself for the drive back to Hà Giang in the morning.

Day 4: Back to Hà Giang City

Morning

Start the last day of your trip with a simple breakfast and stock up on provisions to make the journey back to Hà Giang. From B?o Lâm, take QL34 southwest towards Hà Giang. The road follows the Gâm River most of the time, making for an enjoyable drive along the valley floor. There will still be plenty of twists and a few

passes but nothing as strenuous as before.

Stop in B?c Mê for bite at one of the local food stalls. You?ll find fewer towns in the last stretch before reaching the city.

****Afternoon****

Arrive back in Hà Giang City and treat yourself to some modern comforts after all the miles travelled over the last four days.

**Practical Tips**

**What to Expect**

You?ll be travelling through the northernmost part of Vietnam, and there are limited resources once outside of Ha Giang. Be sure to bring enough cash, as ATMs are scarce.

**How to Get There**

Daytime and overnight buses depart from My Dinh bus station in Hanoi for Ha Giang regularly. Private transfers and tours can also be found online or through tour companies in the capital.

**Motorbike**

You can easily find motorbikes for rent in Hà Giang City. Both Honda and Kawasaki Service Centres are available in town.

**Road Conditions and Safety**

The roads of on this route are in good condition for the most part, however, obstacles and construction can show up anytime. For safety, approach curves with caution, drive during daylight hours and stop after dark.

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